

CASE STUDY 6.17

Toxic K-Pop fandom

As much as K-Pop can be a force for good, such collective behaviour of audiences can descend into evil. Within every fan community lies the competition between them. 'True fans' start acting as gatekeepers to newer fans who must prove their devotion to the community. With an increased sense of devotion comes an increased sense of entitlement (as we saw with Doja Cat's fans in Paraguay) and the conversation can often become hostile as emotions intensify. These emotions can spill over when these audiences develop PSRs and begin stalking their idols. Girls Generation's Kim Taeyeon was almost dragged off stage by a fan intent on kidnapping her.



FIGURE 6.36 Taeyeon of K-Pop group Girls Generation

Within the community, these fans can become hostile, but as a collective, they can aggressively attack anyone who dares challenge their passion. Journalists who question the quality of performances or songs can be viciously attacked online, cyberbullied, threatened and **doxxed**.

doxxed the practice of publishing private and identifying information about a particular individual on the internet, typically with malicious intention

Analysis

Research the nature of toxic fandom that has evolved from the K-Pop movement.

1 Explain the nature of this toxic fandom.

2 Research recent examples of toxic K-Pop fandom. Explain the role of PSRs in your research.

AUDIENCES AND THEIR DATA

The sheer level of choice that audiences have today will only increase this atomisation, since individual users can easily search and seek out the perfect content for the perfect moment. You may be more likely to seek out educational content for a project during school hours, yet after a long week of assessments, you may exhausted and seek out mindless entertainment on Friday nights. Netflix knows this. Because while you are watching it, it's watching you.

The audience as the product

If the media service you are using is free, then *you* are the product. Despite audience agency, changes in media structures and production now being in the hands of the audience, much of it comes at a high price. Global media institutions like TikTok, Facebook, YouTube and Google all provide a platform for audiences to publish, produce and speak to the world, and all the while, they are harvesting your data.

Every click, like, view, swipe and scroll are recorded in detail. Your behaviour across internet platforms is tracked and recorded, shared and sold to the highest bidder, including which site you went to next and how long you stayed there for. Even before Web 2.0 technologies emerged, this practice was pioneered by Google with the express purpose of selling advertising space to companies. If Google could tell a brand like Nike exactly who was interested in its products, then Nike could directly target them with a much higher chance of success.

It seemed innocuous enough. So much so that very few people recognised it was happening and major tech companies said as little as possible about this practice for decades. Fast forward to the 2020s and your data is no longer yours. Your social media apps know you better than you know yourself, and it's a fair guess that you have been using them for a very long time!

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